

2.2 The Digital Wave

Philips and Sony were jointly responsible for inventing and bringing the CD to the masses. Research and development started on the CD back in the '70s but the finished product debuted only in 1982. As usual, it took quite some time for it to be popular because of prohibitive costs. But the CD was extensively marketed and no one could deny its exceptional sound quality and portability, which far outweighed the high cost for many consumers. With the efficiencies of mass production and affordable pricing, CD became the medium of choice by the end of '80s.

Mass acceptance of the CD ended the long running reign of LP records. Skips, crackles, pops, wow, flutter, surface noise, all synonymous with vinyl and magnetic cassette tapes, were now a thing of the past. With plummeting prices and high media reliability software companies soon began distributing software on CDs. Companies such as America Online (AOL) did numerous mass mailings of their online software. And what happened to CDs that went bad? Well, people coined a new term-coasters-that referred to CDs that were unusable and were used for everything else other than their intended purpose.

Continued product development led to the CD-R and CD-R/W formats for both audio and data. Today's higher sampling rates and bit depths have resulted in improved fidelity. The CD with its 44.1 kHz sampling rate at 16-bit depth still reigns as the audio champ, although newer technologies, catering specifically to users who want a more aural, more "being there" experience have evolved.

Technologies such as Super Audio CD, again a Philips-Sony invention and DVD-Audio are slowly doing to the CD, what the CD did to the vinyl. These newer technologies offer higher bit rates and frequencies, which, for an audiophile, is literally pleasure to the ears. We will talk about these formats later.